

Singapore–Cambridge GCE O Level English Language (Syllabus 1184) Paper 2 — Comprehension Practice Paper 30

Time allowed: 1 hour 50 minutes

Total marks for Sections B and C: 45

Instructions to candidates

- Answer **all** questions in Sections B and C.
- The number of marks is given in brackets [] at the end of each question.
- Answer in **complete sentences** where instructed.
- For the summary in Section C, write **no more than 80 words**, not counting the words given to help you begin.

Section B — Text 3 (Narrative) [20 marks]

Text 3: A young amateur cyclist describes his solitary climb up a mountain pass at dawn.

1

At four in the morning the world had not yet decided what it was. The valley below was a dark, soft mass with one or two lights pricked into it, and the road ahead of me climbed away into a greyness that could just as easily have been cloud as stone. I clipped my shoes into the pedals, breathed out a small cone of vapour, and pushed off. The cold went straight through my jersey as though it were paper.

2

For the first kilometre I felt nothing but a sharp, almost unfriendly clarity. My fingers ached on the brake hoods. My legs, half asleep, complained in a low, mechanical way. The hairpins of the lower pass came at me one after another, each a little steeper than the last. I had ridden these bends in summer, in groups of laughing friends, with the smell of pine and warm tarmac in the air. At this hour, alone, they felt like a different road altogether — quieter, sterner, and unwilling to flatter me.

3

I found my rhythm somewhere around the third kilometre. The legs accepted what was being asked of them. The breath settled. The little click of the freewheel became a small private music, and the road, narrowing as it climbed, began to feel less like an obstacle and more like a long, patient conversation. I do not know whether other cyclists feel this. The world shrinks to a circle of light from your front lamp and the strip of road inside it; everything else — the cold, the dark, the questions waiting at the bottom — politely steps outside.

4

Three-quarters of the way up, the road did what mountain roads do. It got cruel. The gradient stiffened to something that my legs read, instantly, as wrong. My lungs, which had been managing, began to argue. Somewhere behind my breastbone a small, reasonable voice that I had been ignoring for an hour cleared its throat and pointed out, very politely, that no one knew where I was, that it was still very

cold, that I had not slept properly, and that there was, in fact, a perfectly good road that went **down**. I almost stopped. My hand actually rose, of its own accord, towards the brake.

5

And then a second voice, quieter and much older, asked what I would do at breakfast if I turned around now. Not in a sentimental way. It simply put the question in front of me, the way a teacher places a problem on a desk and walks off to let you think about it. I did not answer the voice. I just shifted down one more gear — there was, I discovered, one more gear left — and kept the pedals turning. The cadence dropped. The pain settled into a steady, almost neutral ache. The summit, which I could not yet see, seemed to retreat as I climbed, and then, abruptly, to draw closer.

6

I crested the pass without noticing the exact moment. The road levelled. My legs, surprised, briefly forgot what they had been doing. I freewheeled the last few metres into a small gravel pull-off and stopped, one foot down, the other still clipped in, my heart so loud in my ears that I half expected the dawn to hear it.

7

And then, as if it had been waiting, the sun came up. It did not creep. It vaulted over the eastern ridge in one warm, unembarrassed motion, and the whole valley I had climbed out of was suddenly gold. The cold on my arms did not vanish, but it changed character; it became friendly, almost grateful. I sat on the top tube of the bike and watched the light reach me — first my hands, then my shoulders, then, last of all, my face — and I understood, in a way I could not have explained to anyone at sea level, that the climb had been the price of admission, and that the sunrise was free only because I had paid it.

8

I rode down the other side an hour later, into a different valley and a different day. I have ridden longer routes since, and faster ones, and ones with much better company. None of them have ever felt quite the same. Sometimes, in the middle of a noisy afternoon, I remember the quiet of that road before dawn, and the gear I did not know I had, and the small private music of the freewheel, and I think: that boy, alone in the cold, was learning something the warm rooms of the world could never have taught him.

From Paragraph 1

1. The narrator says that at four in the morning “the world had not yet decided what it was.” Explain, in your own words, what this phrase suggests about the scene. [2]

2. The narrator writes that the cold “went straight through my jersey as though it were paper.” What does this comparison tell us about his clothing and the temperature? [2]

From Paragraph 2

3. The narrator says the road, at this hour, was “quieter, sterner, and unwilling to flatter me.” Explain how this language makes the road feel different from how it had felt before. [2]

From Paragraph 3

4. The narrator describes the click of the freewheel as “a small private music.” What does this phrase suggest about his state of mind at this point in the climb? [2]

5. The narrator writes that “everything else... politely steps outside.”

(a) What is **unusual** about the way the narrator describes his worries here? [1]

(b) What does this suggest about the effect of the climb on his mind? [1]

From Paragraph 4

6. In Paragraph 4 the narrator says the road “got cruel.” Explain how the language used in this paragraph makes the climb feel like a battle. Support your answer with **two** details from Paragraph 4. [3]

From Paragraph 5

7. The narrator says the second voice asked its question “the way a teacher places a problem on a desk and walks off to let you think about it.” What does this comparison suggest about the **manner** of the inner voice? [2]

8. The narrator writes that “there was, I discovered, one more gear left.” What does this short remark suggest about the narrator, beyond the literal meaning? [1]

From Paragraph 6

9. Give **one** piece of evidence from Paragraph 6 that shows the narrator was physically exhausted when he reached the top. [1]

From Paragraph 7

10. The narrator says the sunrise was “free only because I had paid it.” Explain, in your own words, what he means by this. [2]

From Paragraph 8

11. What is the **tone** of the final sentence of the text? [1]

Section C — Text 4 (Non-narrative) [25 marks]

Text 4: A feature article on the rise of “doomscrolling” and its effects on the mind.

1

The word entered ordinary speech only a few years ago, but the habit it describes is now almost universal. To “doomscroll” is to keep moving one’s thumb down a feed of bad news long after one knows that it is making one miserable. Floods in one country, an outbreak in another, a small political insult, a celebrity disgrace, a war one cannot influence — the items vary, but the posture does not. The user, propped against the pillows at midnight or curled on the sofa at the end of a long day, scrolls and scrolls, and reports, when asked, that they cannot quite explain why.

2

The neuroscience is, by now, fairly well understood. The human brain evolved in a world in which sudden threats — a snapped twig, a distant cry — mattered far more than ordinary good news. Bad news is, in the strict biological sense, “sticky”: it lodges in the attention more readily than positive information, because attending to it once protected our ancestors from being eaten. A study published in **Nature Human Behaviour** in 2021 found that negative headlines, on average, attracted 60 per cent more clicks than neutral ones, even when readers reported afterwards that they had not enjoyed reading them. The behaviour, in other words, is not a moral failing; it is a feature of how the brain assigns importance.

3

Algorithmic feeds have, with remarkable efficiency, learned to exploit this feature. A recommendation engine has no opinion about your well-being. It has only one task: to predict what will keep your eyes on the screen for one more second. Since alarming content is, on average, more “engaging”, the engine learns, by simple feedback, to serve more of it. The user who watches one upsetting video is shown a second, then a third; the news app that detects a slowing thumb offers up a fresh outrage to revive it. Researchers at the University of Oxford described this loop, in a 2022 paper, as “a marriage of an ancient instinct and an industrial-grade delivery system.”

4

The effect on mental health is now, finally, beginning to be measured rather than merely suspected. A long-running survey at the American Psychological Association has found that respondents who reported more than two hours of news scrolling per day were significantly more likely to describe themselves as anxious, sleep-deprived, and “permanently bracing for the next bad thing”, even when their personal circumstances were perfectly stable. Particularly worrying is the effect on the young: a 2023 report by Singapore’s Institute of Mental Health noted a sharp rise, among teenagers, in what clinicians have begun to call “ambient dread” — a low-grade, free-floating worry not attached to any particular event.

5

There is also the quieter cost, the one that does not show up on a clinical questionnaire: the slow erosion of concentration. A reader who is used to consuming six tragedies in ninety seconds finds it harder, afterwards, to sit with a single paragraph of a book. The mind, having been trained to expect a fresh shock every few inches of screen, grows restless when offered anything slower. Teachers, librarians and editors have all reported the same complaint: it is not that young readers cannot read; it is that, when offered a long article, they reach reflexively for a thumb-flick that is no longer there.

6

The response from the platforms has been, at best, half-hearted. Most large social networks now offer “time-spent” dashboards and, in some cases, optional reminders to take a break. A few have begun to flag and slow the spread of obvious disinformation. None, however, has been willing to alter the fundamental design — the infinite, refreshing, downward-scrolling feed — that produces the problem. A

2024 European Commission report concluded, rather drily, that voluntary measures had “not yet been observed to produce measurable change”, and that the underlying business model “rewards exactly the patterns the platforms claim to discourage”.

7

Practically, then, the work falls to the user. Researchers and clinicians broadly converge on a handful of simple measures. The first is **delay**: keep the phone out of the bedroom, or at least out of the first hour of the morning and the last hour of the night, when the impulse to scroll is at its weakest defence. The second is **replacement**: a paper book, a short walk, even a dull crossword — anything that gives the restless brain a slower object to settle on. The third is **limits**: scheduled, finite blocks of news, ideally from a small number of trusted sources, rather than an endless drip. None of this is heroic. None of it requires the platforms to change. It does, however, require the small, repeated honesty of admitting that the scroll, however good it feels in the moment, is not, in any sense that matters, doing one any good.

From Paragraph 1

12. The writer says that “the items vary, but the posture does not.” Explain, in your own words, what the writer means by this. [2]

From Paragraph 2

13. According to Paragraph 2, why is bad news described as “sticky”? Answer in your own words. [2]

14. The writer cites a study in which negative headlines attracted “60 per cent more clicks than neutral ones, even when readers reported afterwards that they had not enjoyed reading them.” Why does the writer include the second half of this sentence? [2]

From Paragraph 3

15. Explain, in your own words, what the writer means when he says a recommendation engine “has no opinion about your well-being.” [2]

16. What is the effect of the phrase “a marriage of an ancient instinct and an industrial-grade delivery system”? [2]

From Paragraph 4

17. The writer says that some respondents felt “permanently bracing for the next bad thing.” Explain what this phrase suggests about their state of mind. [2]

18. What is **worrying** about the rise of “ambient dread” among teenagers, according to Paragraph 4? [2]

From Paragraph 5

19. Give **two** details from Paragraph 5 that show how doomscrolling damages concentration. [2]

From Paragraph 6

20. What is the writer’s **tone** when he says the platforms’ response has been “at best, half-hearted”? [1]

From Paragraph 7

21. The writer ends the article by saying that the user’s task requires “the small, repeated honesty of admitting” that scrolling is not doing them any good. Explain what is **effective** about this ending. [2]

22. Summary question [6 marks for content, 7 marks for use of own words and style]

Using your own words as far as possible, summarise **why doomscrolling is so harmful**, and **what individuals can practically do about it**, as outlined in the text.

Use **only** material from **Paragraphs 4 to 7** of Text 4.

Your summary must be in **continuous writing** (not note form). It must **not** be longer than **80 words** (not counting the words given to help you begin).

Begin your summary as follows:

Doomscrolling is harmful because ...

— END OF PAPER —